

The Most Dangerous Game

Richard Connell · 1924

First published: Collier's, 19 Jan 1924

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

Common Core edition (standards shown for this framework only)

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson 1: introduction (author, context, reception, overview)
4. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
5. Unit test (eleven rigor versions) with answer keys and scoring guides
6. Final paper
7. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/O._Henry_Memorial_Award_Prize_Stories_of_1924/The_Most_Dangerous_Game (revision 12072546), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 9–12 (accessible text, well suited to the scaffolded-support track; scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). The scaffolded-support track works from the full text with scaffolds. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 2 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Most Dangerous Game suggest about hunter and hunted?
- What does The Most Dangerous Game suggest about civilization and savagery?
- What does The Most Dangerous Game suggest about survival?

Objectives

- Students will cite at least 2 quotations, with locations, to support each written claim about what the text says explicitly and implicitly (scored on the writing-prompt rubric).
- Students will trace one theme across at least 3 sections of the story in the final paper, earning at least 70 of 100 rubric points.
- Students will explain how characters, setting and point of view interact in at least 3 exit tickets, each meeting the claim-evidence-reasoning criteria.
- Students will determine the in-context meaning of taught vocabulary, scoring at least 80% on the vocabulary items of the story quizzes.
- Students will write an argument with a clear claim, reasons and relevant evidence, scoring at least 80% on the unit test's short-answer scoring guides.

Standards: Common Core

RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4

Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org

Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Scaffolded support through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	*Introduction: author, context and reception* The Most Dangerous Game	2 × 90 min (180 min)	*hunter and hunted* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Introduction: author, context and reception • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Introduction to The Most Dangerous Game

Objective: Students will explain, in a 3-sentence exit ticket, how one fact about Richard Connell's life or times connects to hunter and hunted in “The Most Dangerous Game”, and will set up a reading journal with a prediction and a question for each of 3 themes (hunter and hunted, civilization and savagery, survival).

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2

Author biography

Richard Connell was born in Poughkeepsie, New York, on 17 October 1893. He reported for newspapers as a teenager, graduated from Harvard, worked in advertising and served in France in the First World War. He became a prolific magazine writer and Hollywood screenwriter; his story for Meet John Doe (1941) earned an Academy Award nomination. He died in Beverly Hills on 22 November 1949.

Historical and cultural context

Written after the First World War, in which Connell served, and at the height of the fashion for big-game hunting safaris among wealthy Americans and Europeans. General Zaroff is a Cossack aristocrat who fled the Russian Revolution of 1917.

Publication and reception, then and now

First published in Collier's on 19 January 1924; it won the O. Henry Memorial Award.

Then: An instant popular success, filmed in 1932.

Now: One of the most-taught stories in American schools, the model of suspense and the source of countless "human hunt" plots.

Overview (spoiler-free)

Rainsford, a famous big-game hunter, falls overboard near the mysterious Ship-Trap Island and finds the château of General Zaroff, who has grown bored with hunting animals.

Main themes

- hunter and hunted.
- civilization versus savagery.
- reason and instinct.

Why it matters

It asks students to think about empathy and violence, and teaches suspense and conflict.

Spoilers · teacher only

Zaroff hunts shipwrecked men; he hunts Rainsford for three days. Rainsford escapes by leaping into the sea, ambushes Zaroff in his bedroom, and the story ends with Rainsford sleeping in Zaroff's bed, implying he killed him.

Lesson plan (90 minutes)

> **0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)**
> Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
> *Before we open The Most Dangerous Game: Is hunting animals for sport different from hunting for food?*
> **Prompt:** Before we open The Most Dangerous Game: Is hunting animals for sport different from hunting for food?

> **8–18 min · Key terms · I do (10 min)**
> Key literary terms for the unit.
> *conflict; suspense; foreshadowing; irony; character foil.*

> **18–28 min · Mini-lecture: author, context, reception · I do (10 min)**
> Mini-lecture on the author, the historical context and the reception (read or adapt the script).
> *About the author. Richard Connell was born in Poughkeepsie, New York, on 17 October 1893. He reported for newspapers as a teenager, graduated from Harvard, worked in advertising and served in France in the First World War. He became a prolific magazine writer and Hollywood screenwriter; his story for Meet John Doe (1941) earned an Academy Award nomination. He died in Beverly Hills on 22 November 1949. The world of the book. Written after the First World War, in which Connell served, and at the height of the fashion for big-game hunting safaris among wealthy Americans and Europeans. General Zaroff is a Cossack aristocrat who fled the Russian Revolution of 1917. Publication and reception. First published in Collier's on 19 January 1924; it won the O. Henry Memorial Award. Then: An instant popular success, filmed in 1932. Now: One of the most-taught stories in American schools, the model of suspense and the source of countless "human hunt" plots.*

28–40 min · I do: the book in one passage · I do (12 min)
Model a close reading of one passage using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees" slowly and put it in my own words: Rainsford claims the world is made up of two classes, the hunters and the huntees. Next, craft. I notice the confident, simple claim, stated as if it were a law of nature. The strongest word is "classes": it sorts living things into fixed ranks, the same logic Zaroff uses to justify hunting men. Then, effect. How does Rainsford's line set up the irony of the whole story? My answer: Rainsford's own belief will be turned against him when Zaroff decides humans are fair prey; the line forces him to face what his attitude means once he becomes the hunted.

> *The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees* (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 14)

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees" slowly and put it in my own words: Rainsford claims the world is made up of two classes, the hunters and the huntees. Next, craft. I notice the confident, simple claim, stated as if it were a law of nature. The strongest word is "classes": it sorts living things into fixed ranks, the same logic Zaroff uses to justify hunting men. Then, effect. How does Rainsford's line set up the irony of the whole story? My answer: Rainsford's own belief will be turned against him when Zaroff decides humans are fair prey; the line forces him to face what his attitude means once he becomes the hunted.

40–55 min · We do: overview and themes · We do (15 min)
Read the spoiler-free overview together and name the themes to track.
What the book is about (no spoilers): Rainsford, a famous big-game hunter, falls overboard near the mysterious Ship-Trap Island and finds the château of General Zaroff, who has grown bored with hunting animals. Themes to track: hunter and hunted.: civilization versus savagery.: reason and instinct.:

55–70 min · You do: reading journal · You do (15 min)
Set up a reading journal: one page per theme, with a prediction and a question (example given).
Set up a reading journal: one page per theme with a prediction and a question. Page: hunter and hunted. Prediction: Rainsford, who says the world is made of hunters and huntees, will have that belief tested on Ship-Trap Island. Question: how will General Zaroff's idea of sport change Rainsford's view?
Task: Set up a reading journal for The Most Dangerous Game: one page per theme, each with a prediction and a question.
Exemplar: Page: hunter and hunted. Prediction: Rainsford, who says the world is made of hunters and huntees, will have that belief tested on Ship-Trap Island. Question: how will General Zaroff's idea of sport change Rainsford's view?

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Whole-class discussion: why the book is still taught.
Why does The Most Dangerous Game still matter? It asks students to think about empathy and violence, and teaches suspense and conflict.
Anchor question: Why might The Most Dangerous Game still be taught today?
Facilitation: It asks students to think about empathy and violence, and teaches suspense and conflict.

80–87 min · Exit ticket · You do (7 min)
Exit ticket on the author and context (answer given).
Connell served in World War I and wrote this story in 1924. How might his war experience shape a story about hunting men? Answer: Accept answers such as: he had seen men killing men; he questions violence; the story asks whether killing can be a game.
Exit ticket: Connell served in World War I and wrote this story in 1924. How might his war experience shape a story about hunting men?
Answer: Accept answers such as: he had seen men killing men; he questions violence; the story asks whether killing can be a game.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Preview the first reading.
Tomorrow we begin reading: The Most Dangerous Game.

Teacher notes · sources: Britannica, "Richard Connell" (https://www.britannica.com/biography/Richard-Connell); O. Henry Prize Stories history (https://www.penguinrandomhouse.com/series/OHP/the-o-henry-prize-stories/)

Flags (verify before teaching):

- Content note: violence and a hunted human; Zaroff's servant Ivan and some references reflect period stereotypes. Collier's date commonly cited; verify.

Lesson 2: The Most Dangerous Game

Focus: the hunter becoming the hunted

Objective: Students will analyze how conflict develops in "The Most Dangerous Game" by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Content note (killing of humans for sport, violence, zaroff's racist hierarchy of victims (racist language), alcohol or drugs (mentioned)): Sensitive content: Killing of humans for sport; violence; Zaroff's racist hierarchy of victims (racist language). Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail. This section mentions drinking or a drug ("… le the general was sitting, alone. "You'll have a cocktail, Mr. Rainsford," he suggested. The cock…"). Treat it as period custom or plot detail; name it plainly and don't glamorize it.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes killing of humans for sport; violence; Zaroff's racist hierarchy of victims (racist language).
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

Big-game hunter Sanger Rainsford falls overboard near Ship-Trap Island and finds the chateau of General Zaroff, a Russian aristocrat bored with hunting animals who now hunts shipwrecked sailors. Rainsford refuses to join and becomes the prey for three days. He builds traps that kill a servant and a hound, then leaps into the sea. That night he waits in Zaroff's bedroom; they fight, and Rainsford sleeps in Zaroff's bed.

Background: Published in Collier's on 19 January 1924, after the First World War, in which Connell served. Big-game safaris were a fashionable sport.

Significance: Among the most anthologized American stories; it appears in Glencoe's grade 9 lesson plans and Gale's Short Stories for Students, vol. 1.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Is it ever acceptable to hunt for sport? Where would you draw the line? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to hunter and hunted because.... Content note before we start: Heads-up: this story includes killing of humans for sport; violence; Zaroff's racist hierarchy of victims (racist language).
Prompt: Is it ever acceptable to hunt for sport? Where would you draw the line?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to hunter and hunted because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Rainsford learns empathy through terror.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: bizarre — conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual; wrestled — struggled with effort (out of something); complimented — praised; affable — diffusing warmth and friendliness; luckily — by good fortune. "affable": Origin: French affable; earlier Latin affābilis.
Words: bizarre: conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual · wrestled: struggled with effort (out of something) · complimented: praised · affable: diffusing warmth and friendliness · luckily: by good fortune

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Published in Collier's on 19 January 1924, after the First World War, in which Connell served. Big-game safaris were a fashionable sport. Among the most anthologized American stories; it appears in Glencoe's grade 9 lesson plans and Gale's Short Stories for Students, vol. 1. Foreshadowing: Ship-Trap Island's reputation and Rainsford's dismissal of animals' feelings. Irony: The hunter becomes the hunted; Zaroff's "civilized" manners hide savagery. Conflict: Man versus man, and man versus nature. Watch for the island: a trap; Zaroff's world.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees" slowly and put it in my own words: On the yacht, Rainsford tells Whitney that the world is made up of two classes, hunters and huntees. Next, craft. I notice the neat two-part division and the made-up joking word "huntees," which makes the hunted sound unimportant. The strongest word is "huntees": the comic word shows he gives no thought to how the hunted animal feels. Then, effect. What does Rainsford's view of the world show about him at the start? My answer: At the start, Rainsford's view that the world is made of hunters and huntees shows his confidence that he will always be the hunter; the story reverses this by making him Zaroff's prey.

> *The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees* (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 14)

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees" slowly and put it in my own words: On the yacht, Rainsford tells Whitney that the world is made up of two classes, hunters and huntees. Next, craft. I notice the neat two-part division and the made-up joking word "huntees," which makes the hunted sound unimportant. The strongest word is "huntees": the comic word shows he gives no thought to how the hunted animal feels. Then, effect. What does Rainsford's view of the world show about him at the start? My answer: At the start, Rainsford's view that the world is made of hunters and huntees shows his confidence that he will always be the hunter; the story reverses this by making him Zaroff's prey.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Zaroff's belief. Look at the craft: The hunter becomes the hunted; Zaroff's "civilized" manners hide savagery. Ask: How does this line connect to hunter and hunted? Expected: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. (Zaroff's belief.)

> *Instinct is no match for reason* (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 95)

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Zaroff's belief. Look at the craft: The hunter becomes the hunted; Zaroff's "civilized" manners hide savagery.
Ask: How does this line connect to hunter and hunted?
Expected answer: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. (Zaroff's belief.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the story for foreshadowing, irony (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about the hunter becoming the hunted? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Most Dangerous Game develops the idea of the hunter becoming the hunted. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of conflict and foreshadowing shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Rainsford's early view is turned against him. When the text says "The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees" (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 14), it shows this directly. He tells Whitney "The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees," and Zaroff makes him a huntee; at the end, "He had never slept in a better bed," suggesting he has become a hunter of men too.
Task: Annotate the story for foreshadowing, irony (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about the hunter becoming the hunted? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Most Dangerous Game develops the idea of the hunter becoming the hunted. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of conflict and foreshadowing shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Rainsford's early view is turned against him. When the text says "The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees" (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 14), it shows this directly. He tells Whitney "The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees," and Zaroff makes him a huntee; at the end, "He had never slept in a better bed," suggesting he has become a hunter of men too.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: Is it ever acceptable to hunt for sport? Where would you draw the line? Ask: has Rainsford become like Zaroff?
Anchor question: Is it ever acceptable to hunt for sport? Where would you draw the line?
Facilitation: Ask: has Rainsford become like Zaroff?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Story quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about the hunter becoming the hunted? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Rainsford's early view is turned against him. ("The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees", The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 14). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about the hunter becoming the hunted? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Rainsford's early view is turned against him. ("The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees", The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 14). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how foreshadowing shapes the hunter becoming the hunted. Key takeaway: Rainsford learns empathy through terror.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Foreshadowing:** Ship-Trap Island's reputation and Rainsford's dismissal of animals' feelings.
- **Irony:** The hunter becomes the hunted; Zaroff's "civilized" manners hide savagery.
- **Conflict:** Man versus man, and man versus nature.

Themes and how they develop

- **hunter and hunted:** Rainsford learns empathy through terror.

Symbols and motifs

- **the island:** a trap; Zaroff's world.

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- "The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees" (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 14) His early philosophy.
- "Instinct is no match for reason" (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 95) Zaroff's belief.
- "He had never slept in a better bed, Rainsford decided" (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 211) The ending.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Rainsford's early view is turned against him.
Evidence: "The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees" (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 14)
Reasoning: He tells Whitney "The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees," and Zaroff makes him a huntee; at the end, "He had never slept in a better bed," suggesting he has become a hunter of men too.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
bizarre (adjective)	conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual	*Rainsford's first impression was that the man was singularly handsome; his second was that there was an original, almost bizarre quality about the general's face.*	
wrestled (verb)	struggled with effort (out of something)	*He wrestled himself out of his clothes, and shouted with all his power.*	
complimented (verb)	praised	*When I shot some of his prize turkeys with it, he did not punish me; he complimented me on my marksmanship.*	
affable (adjective)	diffusing warmth and friendliness	*He was finding the general a most thoughtful and affable host, a true cosmopolite.*	"affable": Origin: French affable; earlier Latin affābilis. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/affable#Etymology)
luckily (adverb)	by good fortune	*I, luckily, had invested heavily in American securities, so I shall never have to open a tea room in Monte Carlo or drive a taxi in Paris.*	
narrowly (adverb)	closely; carefully	*Whenever he looked up from his plate he found the general studying him, appraising him narrowly.*	"narrowly": Origin: an English formation from narrow + -ly. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/narrowly#Etymology)
headache (noun)	a pain in the head	*I was lying in my tent with a splitting headache one night when a terrible thought pushed its way into my mind.*	
weaving (verb)	interlace by or as if by weaving	*There, weaving in and out in the pattern of shadow, were black, noiseless forms; the hounds heard him at the window and looked up, expectantly, with their green eyes.*	

protested (verb)	utter words of protest	*"But, my dear fellow," the general protested, "you've only just come.*	
congratulate (verb)	to express pleasure at someone's good fortune	*"Rainsford," called the general, "if you are within sound of my voice, as I suppose you are, let me congratulate you.*	

Discussion questions

1. Is it ever acceptable to hunt for sport? Where would you draw the line?
2. Where does conflict appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with hunter and hunted?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. How does Rainsford reach the island? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: He falls off a yacht and swims ashore
2. What does Zaroff hunt? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Human beings
3. What is Ship-Trap Island known for? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Sailors' dread of it
4. How long must Rainsford survive to win? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Three days
5. Where does the story end? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: In Zaroff's bedroom, with Rainsford in the bed
6. Retell the three most important events of "The Most Dangerous Game" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Big-game hunter Sanger Rainsford falls overboard near Ship-Trap Island and finds the chateau of General Zaroff, a Russian aristocrat bored with hunting animals who now hunts shipwrecked sailors. Rainsford refuses to join and becomes the prey for three days. He builds traps that kill a servant and a hound, then leaps into the sea. That night he waits in Zaroff's bedroom; they fight, and Rainsford…
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in "The Most Dangerous Game"? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does "The Most Dangerous Game" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.

9. Reread: “Rainsford’s first impression was that the man was singularly handsome; his second was that there was an original, almost bizarre quality about the general’s face.” What does “bizarre” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: bizarre: conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual.
10. Reread: “He wrestled himself out of his clothes, and shouted with all his power.” What does “wrestled” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: wrestled: struggled with effort (out of something).

Inferential / analytical

1. What does “The Most Dangerous Game” suggest about the hunter becoming the hunted? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Among the most anthologized American stories; it appears in Glencoe's grade 9 lesson plans and Gale's Short Stories for Students, vol. 1.
2. Find one example of conflict in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for the forces, people or desires pulling against each other.
3. How does the foreshadowing in this story shape what we understand about the hunter becoming the hunted? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: Look for hints, warnings or images that point to later events.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Rainsford's early view is turned against him. Useful evidence: “The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees” (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 14): His early philosophy. On foreshadowing: Ship-Trap Island's reputation and Rainsford's dismissal of animals' feelings. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. In the passage that begins “He struggled up to the surface and tried to cry out, but the wash from the speeding yacht slapped him in the face and the salt water in his open mouth made him gag and strangle.”, why might Connell have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “The Most Dangerous Game”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Big-game hunter Sanger Rainsford falls overboard near Ship-Trap Island and finds the chateau of General Zaroff, a Russian aristocrat bored with hunting animals who now hunts shipwrecked sailors. Rainsford refuses to join and becomes the prey for three days. He builds traps that kill a servant and a…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Most Dangerous Game” set up that the rest of The Most Dangerous Game will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Rainsford's early view is turned against him. Useful evidence: “Instinct is no match for reason” (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 95): Zaroff's belief. Theme link: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Rainsford's early view is turned against him. Useful evidence: “He had never slept in a better bed, Rainsford decided” (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 211): The ending. Theme link: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. The bell-ringer asked: “Is it ever acceptable to hunt for sport? Where would you draw the line?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does irony appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with hunter and hunted? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.6] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Rainsford's early view is turned against him. Useful evidence: “The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees” (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 14): His early philosophy. On irony: The hunter becomes the hunted; Zaroff's "civilized" manners hide savagery. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Background: Published in Collier's on 19 January 1924, after the First World War, in which Connell served. Big-game safaris were a fashionable sport. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Rainsford's early view is turned against him. Useful evidence: “Instinct is no match for reason” (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 95): Zaroff's belief. Theme link: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “Among the most anthologized American stories; it appears in Glencoe's grade 9 lesson plans and Gale's Short Stories for Students, vol. 1.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Rainsford's early view is turned against him. Useful evidence: “He had never slept in a better bed, Rainsford decided” (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 211): The ending. Theme link: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Rainsford's early view is turned against him. Useful evidence: “The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees” (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 14): His early philosophy. Theme link: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Rewrite one moment of “The Most Dangerous Game” from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about the hunter becoming the hunted? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait

8 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.6] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Rainsford's early view is turned against him. Useful evidence: “Instinct is no match for reason” (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 95): Zaroff's belief. Theme link: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. Write three questions of your own about “The Most Dangerous Game”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Rainsford's early view is turned against him. Useful evidence: “He had never slept in a better bed, Rainsford decided” (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 211): The ending. Theme link: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Connect this story to civilization and savagery: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Connell need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Rainsford's early view is turned against him. Useful evidence: “The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees” (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 14): His early philosophy. Theme link: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Is the conflict in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Rainsford's early view is turned against him. Useful evidence: “Instinct is no match for reason” (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 95): Zaroff's belief. On conflict: Man versus man, and man versus nature. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Compare how “The Most Dangerous Game” treats the hunter becoming the hunted with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Most Dangerous Game see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Rainsford's early view is turned against him. Useful evidence: “He had never slept in a better bed, Rainsford decided” (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 211): The ending. Theme link: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. As the final story, does this ending resolve hunter and hunted? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Rainsford's early view is turned against him. Useful evidence: “The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees” (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 14): His early philosophy. On foreshadowing: Ship-Trap Island's reputation and Rainsford's dismissal of animals' feelings. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about the hunter becoming the hunted? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2,

SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Rainsford's early view is turned against him. Useful evidence: “Instinct is no match for reason” (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 95): Zaroff's belief. Theme link: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. What question would you most like to ask Richard Connell about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Rainsford's early view is turned against him. Useful evidence: “He had never slept in a better bed, Rainsford decided” (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 211): The ending. Theme link: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Conflict:** look for the forces, people or desires pulling against each other (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Foreshadowing**: hints, warnings or images that point to later events
- Also notice **Irony**: gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] How does Rainsford reach the island?

   A. He falls off a yacht and swims ashore

   B. He is invited

   C. He is shipwrecked in a storm with friends

   D. His plane crashes

   Key: A (He falls off a yacht and swims ashore)

2. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Where does the story end?

   A. In Zaroff's bedroom, with Rainsford in the bed

   B. On the yacht

   C. In the jungle

   D. At sea

   Key: A (In Zaroff's bedroom, with Rainsford in the bed)

3. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “I was lying in my tent with a splitting _____ one night when a terrible thought pushed its way into my mind.” Word bank: wrestled, bizarre, complimented, headache

   Key: headache

4. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from paragraph 67: “Perhaps,’ said General Zaroff, ‘you were surprised that I _____ your name.” Word bank: glittering, recognized, cigarette, moonless

   Key: recognized

5. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from paragraph 41: "A small, _____ object not far away caught Rainsford's eye and he picked it up." Word bank: mental, unreality, glittering, remarkable
   Key: glittering
6. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 211: "He had never slept in a better bed, Rainsford _____"
   Key: decided
7. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from paragraph 5: "You've good eyes,' said Whitney, with a laugh, 'and I've seen you pick off a moose moving in the brown fall bush at four hundred yards, but even you can't see four miles or so through a _____ Caribbean night." Word bank: moonless, determined, pinched, remarkable
   Key: moonless
8. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] How long must Rainsford survive to win?
   A. A week
   B. A month
   C. Three days
   D. One night

   Key: C (Three days)
9. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 113? "I refuse to believe that so modern and _____ a young man as you seem to be harbours romantic ideas about the value of human life."
   A. civilized
   B. pinched
   C. surmounted
   D. recognized

   Key: A (civilized)
10. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "I, _____, had invested heavily in American securities, so I shall never have to open a tea room in Monte Carlo or drive a taxi in Paris." Word bank: luckily, wrestled, complimented, bizarre
    Key: luckily
11. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from paragraph 21 reveal about the character or situation? "Those fishy blue eyes held a look I never saw there before." Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: The passage (paragraph 21) shows the situation turning on hunter and hunted: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. The words "before" are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.
12. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? "The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees" (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 14) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: His early philosophy. The evidence is "The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees" (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 14). This develops hunter and hunted: Rainsford learns empathy through terror.
13. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from paragraph 117 reveal about the character or situation? "But I think I can show you that your scruples are quite ill founded." Answer in

two or three sentences with one detail.

Sample answer: The passage (paragraph 117) shows the situation turning on hunter and hunted: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. The words “scruples” and “founded” are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

14. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 42 shapes its tone: “The last shot was when he trailed it here and finished it.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “finished” and “trailed” (paragraph 42) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to hunter and hunted: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

15. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 34 shapes its tone: “It came out of the darkness, a high, screaming sound, the sound of an animal in an extremity of anguish and terror.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “extremity” and “screaming” (paragraph 34) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to hunter and hunted: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 190 to the story's treatment of hunter and hunted: “When the general, nursing his bruised shoulder, had gone, Rainsford took up his flight again.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 190) develops hunter and hunted: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. Its words “shoulder” and “general” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “Rainsford had dug himself in in France when a second’s delay meant death.” (paragraph 192), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating hunter and hunted as central.

17. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “There, _____ in and out in the pattern of shadow, were black, noiseless forms; the hounds heard him at the window and looked up, expectantly, with their green eyes.” Word bank: wrestled, bizarre, weaving, complimented

    Key: weaving

18. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What does Zaroff hunt?

    A. Wild boars

    B. Tigers

    C. Human beings

    D. Deer

    Key: C (Human beings)

19. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 14: “The world is made up of two _____—the hunters and the huntees”

    Key: classes

20. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 95: “Instinct is no match for _____”

    Key: reason

21. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 49? “The _____ pointed as rigidly as if the giant were a statue.”

    A. cigarette

B. remarkable

C. revolver

D. headlong

Key: C (revolver)

22. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 175 shapes its tone: “He had not been entirely clear-headed when the château gates snapped shut behind him.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “entirely” and “snapped” (paragraph 175) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to hunter and hunted: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

23. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 51 to the story's treatment of hunter and hunted: “The man’s only answer was to raise with his thumb the hammer of his revolver.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 51) develops hunter and hunted: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. Its words “revolver” and “hammer” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “Ivan had reappeared, and the general spoke to him with lips that moved but gave forth no sound.” (paragraph 60), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating hunter and hunted as central.

24. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 31? “The cry was _____ off short as the blood-warm waters of the Caribbean Sea closed over his head.”

    A. deliberateness

    B. pinched

    C. moonless

    D. mental

    Key: B (pinched)

25. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What is Ship-Trap Island known for?

    A. Rare birds

    B. A lighthouse

    C. Sailors' dread of it

    D. Gold mines

    Key: C (Sailors' dread of it)

26. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 142 shapes its tone: “And now,’ said the general, ‘I want to show you my new collection of heads.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “collection” and “general” (paragraph 142) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to hunter and hunted: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

27. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 72 to the story's treatment of hunter and hunted: “I’ve always thought,’ said Rainsford, ‘that the Cape buffalo is the most dangerous of all big game.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 72) develops hunter and hunted: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. Its words “dangerous” and “thought” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “You are much younger

than I am, Mr. Rainsford, and have not hunted as much, but you perhaps can guess the answer." (paragraph 91), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating hunter and hunted as central.

28. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Evaluate this claim about the story: "Rainsford's early view is turned against him." Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.
Sample answer: The claim is persuasive in part. "The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees" (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 14) supports it: He tells Whitney "The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees," and Zaroff makes him a huntee; at the end, "He had never slept in a better bed," suggesting he has become a hunter of men too. But "Instinct is no match for reason" (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 95) complicates it: the line (Zaroff's belief) shows the same issue from another side, and its "no" marks a limit or reversal the claim passes over. Weighing the two passages, the claim survives, but only once it admits the tension the second passage creates.

29. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 181 to the story's treatment of hunter and hunted: "The general's eyes had left the ground and were traveling inch by inch up the tree." Use one other moment from the story as well.
Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 181) develops hunter and hunted: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. Its words "traveling" and "general" carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in "He slid down from the tree, and struck off again into the woods." (paragraph 186), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating hunter and hunted as central.

30. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Whenever he looked up from his plate he found the general studying him, appraising him _____." Word bank: narrowly, bizarre, wrestled, complimented
Key: narrowly

31. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] In the line "He wrestled himself out of his clothes, and shouted with all his power.", what does "wrestled" most nearly mean?
A. praised
B. conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual
C. struggled with effort (out of something)
D. diffusing warmth and friendliness
Key: C (struggled with effort (out of something))

32. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Which choice best states a central concern of "The Most Dangerous Game"?
A. A story so convincing it becomes real
B. The art of the deadpan tall tale
C. The hunter becoming the hunted
D. Waking into a changed nation
Key: C (The hunter becoming the hunted)

33. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Claim: Rainsford's early view is turned against him. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: "The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees" (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 14).
Sample answer: He tells Whitney "The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees," and Zaroff makes him a huntee; at the end, "He had never slept in a better bed," suggesting he has become a hunter of men too. The evidence is "The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees" (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 14) — His early philosophy. This develops hunter and hunted: Rainsford learns empathy through terror.

34. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] Analyze the word choice in “He had never slept in a better bed, Rainsford decided” (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 211). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
    Sample answer: The ending. The evidence is “He had never slept in a better bed, Rainsford decided” (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 211). This develops hunter and hunted: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. The words “decided” and “better” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect.

35. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] Which literary element does this describe in “The Most Dangerous Game”? Ship-Trap Island's reputation and Rainsford's dismissal of animals' feelings.
    A. Alliteration
    B. Foreshadowing
    C. Imagery
    D. Theme

    Key: B (Foreshadowing)

36. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Program outcome: LeL-C2-LIT-1] In the line “He was finding the general a most thoughtful and affable host, a true cosmopolite.”, what does “affable” most nearly mean?
    A. conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual
    B. diffusing warmth and friendliness
    C. struggled with effort (out of something)
    D. praised

    Key: B (diffusing warmth and friendliness)

37. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Program outcome: LeL-C2-LIT-1] Synthesis: trace how hunter and hunted develops from the opening of “The Most Dangerous Game” to its ending. Use one quotation from each part.
    Sample answer: Near the start, “The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees” (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 14) — His early philosophy. Later, “He had never slept in a better bed, Rainsford decided” (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 211) — The ending. Rainsford learns empathy through terror.

38. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Program outcome: LeL-C3-LIT-1] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Instinct is no match for reason” (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 95) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Zaroff's belief. The evidence is “Instinct is no match for reason” (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 95). This develops hunter and hunted: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. The words “reason” and “match” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. He tells Whitney "The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees," and Zaroff makes him a huntee; at the end, "He had never slept in a better bed," suggesting he has become a hunter of men too.

39. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Program outcome: LeL-GR-LIT-1] In the line “Rainsford’s first impression was that the man was singularly handsome; his second was that there was an original, almost bizarre quality about the general’s face.”, what does “bizarre” most nearly mean?
    A. praised
    B. diffusing warmth and friendliness
    C. struggled with effort (out of something)
    D. conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual

Key: D (conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 6, 1, 7, 21, 9, 13, 11, 15, 22, 14, 23	recall 10, inference 2, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	5, 18, 4, 24, 17, 6, 3, 9, 25, 13, 11, 15, 26, 22, 27, 28	recall 9, inference 2, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	18, 25, 21, 3, 4, 1, 10, 11, 13, 12, 15, 22, 26, 14, 29, 28	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	9, 1, 18, 30, 17, 7, 24, 13, 11, 14, 15, 22, 26, 16, 28, 29	recall 7, inference 2, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	30, 31, 5, 1, 18, 11, 32, 26, 33, 14, 22, 15, 27, 29, 16, 23	recall 5, inference 2, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Freshman	10, 31, 9, 30, 1, 33, 22, 34, 35, 26, 15, 23, 16, 27, 28, 29	recall 5, inference 0, analysis 6, synthesis 5
College Sophomore	36, 31, 10, 30, 1, 18, 34, 15, 22, 26, 23, 28, 29, 16, 27, 37	recall 6, inference 0, analysis 4, synthesis 6
College Junior	7, 1, 10, 18, 25, 15, 22, 14, 35, 26, 27, 28, 23, 38, 16, 29	recall 5, inference 0, analysis 5, synthesis 6
College Senior	19, 1, 18, 25, 7, 32, 26, 34, 14, 15, 22, 28, 23, 27, 16, 29	recall 5, inference 1, analysis 5, synthesis 5
Graduate / PhD	1, 10, 30, 18, 25, 39, 34, 14, 15, 29, 27, 23, 38, 16, 37, 28	recall 6, inference 0, analysis 3, synthesis 7

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “The Most Dangerous Game,” how does Connell show the hunter becoming the hunted? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the conflict you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In The Most Dangerous Game, how does Connell develop the idea of the hunter becoming the hunted? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the conflict in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how The Most Dangerous Game develops the idea of the hunter becoming the hunted. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of conflict and foreshadowing shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.9): Analyze how the structure of The Most Dangerous Game (where it begins, turns and ends) and its conflict shape the reader's understanding of the hunter becoming the hunted. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.9): Two readers disagree about what The Most Dangerous Game suggests about the hunter becoming the hunted. Lay out two plausible

interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's conflict and foreshadowing), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Richard Connell uses conflict in The Most Dangerous Game to complicate the reader's understanding of the hunter becoming the hunted. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate The Most Dangerous Game within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of the hunter becoming the hunted responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read The Most Dangerous Game alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of the hunter becoming the hunted follows or bends those conventions, using the conflict as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Most Dangerous Game and its treatment of the hunter becoming the hunted. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's conflict and foreshadowing, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads The Most Dangerous Game as evidence for a larger claim about the hunter becoming the hunted in The Most Dangerous Game. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads The Most Dangerous Game as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of the hunter becoming the hunted. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Most Dangerous Game.

SAT-style questions

1. *When I shot some of his prize turkeys with it, he did not punish me; he complimented me on my marksmanship.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “complimented” most nearly mean?

   A. utter words of protest

   B. interlace by or as if by weaving

   C. praised

   D. to express pleasure at someone's good fortune

2. *He struggled up to the surface and tried to cry out, but the wash from the speeding yacht slapped him in the face and the salt water in his open mouth made him gag and strangle. Desperately he struck out with strong*

strokes after the receding lights of the yacht, but he stopped before he had swum fifty feet. A certain cool-headedness had come to him; it was not the first time he had been in a tight place. There was a chance that his cries could be heard by someone aboard the yacht, but that chance was slender, and grew more slender as the yacht raced on. He wrestled himself out of his clothes, and shouted with all his power. The lights of the yacht became faint and ever-vanishing fireflies; then they were blotted out entirely by the night.

Which choice best states a central concern of "The Most Dangerous Game"?

A. The hunter becoming the hunted

B. Love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence

C. Reason struggling against terror

D. The cost of wanting to seem richer than you are

SAT key: 1. C (praised); 2. A (The hunter becoming the hunted)

Unit test

The Most Dangerous Game: end test · 90 minutes · 18 questions per rigor version (multiple choice, fill in the blank, short answer). The class rigor level picks the version; student auto-adjust applies.

Short-answer scoring guides

Scaffolded support and HS Freshman (2 points): correct answer in a complete sentence with a detail from the text. HS Sophomore to HS Senior (3 points): claim, one accurate quotation, one sentence of explanation. AP to College Sophomore (4 points): precise claim, two embedded quotations, commentary on word choice or structure, link to theme. College Junior to Graduate (5 points): nuanced thesis, close reading of two passages, synthesis across sections, a competing reading answered. Each item lists a sample answer; partial credit is described in the app.

Unit test: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 43? "Eagerly he hurried along, now slipping on a rotten log or a loose stone, but making headway; night was _____ to settle down on the island."

   A. remarkable
   B. beginning
   C. unreality
   D. recognized

   Key: B (beginning)

2. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from paragraph 37: "Ten minutes of _____ effort brought another sound to his ears—the most welcome he had ever heard—the muttering and growling of the sea breaking on a rocky shore." Word bank: cigarette, determined, civilized, moonless
   Key: determined

3. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 22? "What I felt was a—a _____ chill; a sort of sudden dread."

   A. mental
   B. determined
   C. civilized
   D. thought

   Key: A (mental)

4. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 37? "He flung himself down at the jungle edge and tumbled _____ into the deepest sleep of his life."

   A. surmounted
   B. headlong
   C. pinched
   D. glittering

   Key: B (headlong)

5. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from paragraph 29: "It's so dark,' he _____, 'that I could sleep without closing my eyes; the night would be my eyelids——" Word bank: surmounted, deliberateness, mental, thought

   Key: thought

6. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from paragraph 45: "The stone steps were real enough; the massive door with a leering gargoyle for a knocker was real enough; yet above it all hung an air of _____." Word bank: unreality, mental, deliberateness, beginning

   Key: unreality

7. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from paragraph 52: "In a cultivated voice marked by a slight accent that gave it added precision and _____, he said: 'It is a very great pleasure and honour to welcome Mr. Sanger Rainsford, the celebrated hunter, to my home.'" Word bank: moonless, deliberateness, recognized, thought

   Key: deliberateness

8. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 63? "The dining room to which Ivan conducted him was in many ways _____."

   A. deliberateness
   B. pinched
   C. remarkable
   D. thought

   Key: C (remarkable)

9. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from paragraph 99: "The general smiled the quiet smile of one who has faced an obstacle and _____ it with success." Word bank: deliberateness, surmounted, moonless, determined

   Key: surmounted

10. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 80? "The general took from his pocket a gold _____ case and offered his guest a long black cigarette with a silver tip; it was perfumed and gave off a smell like incense."

    A. revolver
    B. pinched
    C. cigarette
    D. recognized

    Key: C (cigarette)

11. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from paragraph 60 reveal about the character or situation? "Ivan had reappeared, and the general spoke to him with lips that moved but gave forth no sound." Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The passage (paragraph 60) shows the situation turning on civilization and savagery: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. The words "reappeared" and "general" are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

12. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from paragraph 186 reveal about the character or situation? "He slid down from the tree, and struck off again into the woods." Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The passage (paragraph 186) shows the situation turning on civilization and savagery: Rainsford learns

empathy through terror. The words "struck" are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

13. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from paragraph 39 reveal about the character or situation? "But what kind of men, he wondered, in so forbidding a place?" Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The passage (paragraph 39) shows the situation turning on survival: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. The words "forbidding" and "wondered" are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

14. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from paragraph 169 reveal about the character or situation? "Oh,' said the general, 'in that case—— But why discuss that now?" Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The passage (paragraph 169) shows the situation turning on survival: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. The words "discuss" and "general" are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

15. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Which of these passages comes earliest in the story?

    A. "What I felt was a—a mental chill; a sort of sudden dread."

    B. "Sometimes I think evil is a tangible thing—with wave lengths, just as sound and light have."

    C. "Those fishy blue eyes held a look I never saw there before."

    D. "You've good eyes,' said Whitney, with a laugh, 'and I've seen you pick off a moose moving in the brown fall bush at four hundred yards, but…"

    Key: D ("You've good eyes,' said Whitney, with a laugh, 'and I've seen you pick off a moose moving in the brown fall bush at four hundred yards, but…")

16. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 125 shapes its tone: "Rainsford's eyes saw only blackness, and then, as the general pressed a button, far out to sea Rainsford saw the flash of lights." Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words "blackness" and "general" (paragraph 125) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to civilization and savagery: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

17. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 178 shapes its tone: "He flattened himself down on the limb and, through a screen of leaves almost as thick as tapestry, he watched...." Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words "flattened" and "tapestry" (paragraph 178) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to survival: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

18. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 154 to the story's treatment of civilization and savagery: "He saw the dead black eyes of the general on him, studying him." Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 154) develops civilization and savagery: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. Its words "studying" and "general" carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in "Oh,' said the general, 'in that case—— But why discuss that now?" (paragraph 169), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating civilization and savagery as central.

19. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 64 shapes its tone: “The cocktail was surpassingly good; and, Rainsford noted, the table appointments were of the finest—the linen, the crystal, the silver, the china.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “appointments” and “surpassingly” (paragraph 64) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to survival: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

20. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 91 shapes its tone: “You are much younger than I am, Mr. Rainsford, and have not hunted as much, but you perhaps can guess the answer.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “perhaps” and “younger” (paragraph 91) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to civilization and savagery: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

21. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 37 to the story's treatment of civilization and savagery: “Gasping, his hands raw, he reached a flat place at the top.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 37) develops civilization and savagery: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. Its words “reached” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “But what kind of men, he wondered, in so forbidding a place?” (paragraph 39), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating civilization and savagery as central.

22. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 192 shapes its tone: “Rainsford had dug himself in in France when a second’s delay meant death.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “himself” and “second” (paragraph 192) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to civilization and savagery: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

23. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 177 to the story's treatment of civilization and savagery: “Night found him leg-weary, with hands and face lashed by the branches, on a thickly wooded ridge.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 177) develops civilization and savagery: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. Its words “branches” and “thickly” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “He flattened himself down on the limb and, through a screen of leaves almost as thick as tapestry, he watched....” (paragraph 178), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating civilization and savagery as central.

24. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 31 to the story's treatment of survival: “He strained his eyes in the direction from which the reports had come, but it was like trying to see through a blanket.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 31) develops survival: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. Its words “direction” and “strained” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “It came out of the darkness, a high, screaming sound, the sound of an animal in an extremity of anguish and terror.” (paragraph 34), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating survival as central.

25. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 24 shapes its tone: “Sometimes I think evil is a tangible thing—with wave lengths, just as sound and light have.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

Sample answer: The words “tangible” and “lengths” (paragraph 24) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to civilization and savagery: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

26. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 188 shapes its tone: “Nothing escaped those searching black eyes, no crushed blade of grass, no bent twig, no mark, no matter how faint, in the moss.” Pick two words and explain their effect.
Sample answer: The words “searching” and “escaped” (paragraph 188) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to survival: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

27. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 103 to the story's treatment of survival: “Oh,’ said the general, ‘it supplies me with the most exciting hunting in the world.” Use one other moment from the story as well.
Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 103) develops survival: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. Its words “exciting” and “supplies” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “But I think I can show you that your scruples are quite ill founded.” (paragraph 117), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating survival as central.

28. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 193 to the story's treatment of survival: “It seemed to Rainsford that the general was coming with unusual swiftness; he was not feeling his way along, foot by foot.” Use one other moment from the story as well.
Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 193) develops survival: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. Its words “swiftness” and “feeling” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “Those fishy blue eyes held a look I never saw there before.” (paragraph 21), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating survival as central.

29. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 132 to the story's treatment of survival: “I give him a supply of food and an excellent hunting knife.” Use one other moment from the story as well.
Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 132) develops survival: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. Its words “excellent” and “hunting” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “And now,’ said the general, ‘I want to show you my new collection of heads.” (paragraph 142), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating survival as central.

30. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] In the line “When I shot some of his prize turkeys with it, he did not punish me; he complimented me on my marksmanship.”, what does “complimented” most nearly mean?

    A. praised
    B. diffusing warmth and friendliness
    C. struggled with effort (out of something)
    D. conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual

    Key: A (praised)

31. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 46 shapes its tone: “The door opened then, opened as suddenly as if it were on a spring, and Rainsford stood blinking in the river of glaring gold light that poured out.” Pick two words and explain their effect.
Sample answer: The words “blinking” and “suddenly” (paragraph 46) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than

neutral. That weight points the reader to survival: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

32. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] Connect this passage from paragraph 44 to the story's treatment of civilization and savagery: “But as he forged along he saw to his great astonishment that all the lights were in one enormous building—a lofty structure with pointed towers plunging upward into the gloom.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 44) develops civilization and savagery: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. Its words “astonishment” and “structure” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “The door opened then, opened as suddenly as if it were on a spring, and Rainsford stood blinking in the river of…” (paragraph 46), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating civilization and savagery as central.

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18	recall 10, inference 5, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	1, 4, 8, 3, 2, 10, 9, 7, 6, 5, 14, 13, 15, 12, 19, 20, 16, 21	recall 10, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	1, 5, 4, 9, 6, 8, 3, 13, 14, 15, 11, 12, 15, 17, 22, 20, 23, 24	recall 7, inference 6, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	10, 3, 1, 7, 8, 5, 15, 14, 15, 11, 12, 13, 22, 25, 19, 26, 27, 28	recall 6, inference 6, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	2, 9, 1, 6, 8, 12, 13, 15, 14, 15, 11, 26, 17, 16, 25, 27, 28, 29	recall 5, inference 6, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	8, 1, 30, 5, 15, 11, 14, 20, 17, 31, 22, 26, 25, 28, 27, 21, 23, 24	recall 4, inference 3, analysis 6, synthesis 5
College Freshman	5, 8, 3, 12, 15, 11, 14, 22, 20, 19, 31, 25, 26, 29, 23, 28, 27, 32	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 6, synthesis 5
College Sophomore	7, 5, 15, 11, 14, 15, 22, 16, 17, 26, 20, 31, 21, 23, 32, 18, 27, 29	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 6, synthesis 6
College Junior	7, 30, 11, 15, 22, 25, 20, 26, 16, 31, 27, 23, 28, 32, 24, 18, 29, 21	recall 2, inference 2, analysis 6, synthesis 8
College Senior	5, 3, 14, 20, 31, 25, 16, 19, 22, 26, 32, 28, 29, 27, 23, 21, 24, 18	recall 2, inference 1, analysis 7, synthesis 8
Graduate / PhD	7, 30, 15, 25, 19, 22, 31, 20, 17, 16, 23, 24, 21, 18, 27, 29, 32, 28	recall 2, inference 1, analysis 7, synthesis 8

Final paper

The Most Dangerous Game: final paper (formal literary analysis). Choose one prompt.

1. Analyze how Richard Connell develops hunter and hunted across The Most Dangerous Game. Trace the idea through at least three moments (beginning, middle and end) and argue what the ending finally suggests.
2. Choose one recurring symbol, image or motif in The Most Dangerous Game and argue how its meaning changes over the story and why that change matters to civilization and savagery.
3. Analyze a central character's choices in The Most Dangerous Game. Argue whether the story judges that character, and how its structure or point of view shapes your answer.
4. Two readers disagree about whether The Most Dangerous Game finally endorses or criticizes its society's view of survival. Weigh both readings and argue for one, answering the strongest objection.

Length: Scaffolded support 500-700 words; HS Freshman 700-900 words; HS Sophomore 900-1,100 words; HS Junior 1,000-1,300 words; HS Senior 1,200-1,500 words; AP 1,300-1,600 words; College Freshman 1,500-2,000 words; College Sophomore 2,000-2,500 words; College Junior 2,500-3,000 words; College Senior 3,000-4,000 words; Graduate / PhD 4,000-6,000 words

Evidence requirement: at least 4 quotations from at least two parts of the story. Quote the reading text exactly and cite the paragraph (MLA style). HS Senior and above: one scholarly or historical source; College Sophomore and above: two, cited in MLA.

Criterion	Points	Descriptor	Exemplary	Proficient	Developing	Beginning
Thesis	20	A specific, arguable claim that answers the prompt and organizes the paper.	Specific, arguable and precise; it organizes every section.	Clear and arguable, but broad in places.	States a topic or a summary more than an argument.	Missing, or restates the prompt.
Evidence	25	Well-chosen, accurately quoted and cited passages from across the work, meeting the evidence requirement.	Accurate, well-chosen quotations from across the work, all cited; meets the requirement.	Accurate and cited, but clustered in one part of the work.	Too few quotations, or some inaccurate or uncited.	Little or no quoted evidence.
Analysis	30	Explains how language, structure and literary elements create meaning; goes beyond summary.	Explains how specific words, structure and devices create meaning; weighs a competing reading.	Explains the evidence, with some close reading.	Mostly summary; the link to the claim is asserted, not shown.	Summary only.

Organization	15	Logical progression, clear topic sentences and transitions; introduction and conclusion frame the argument.	Each paragraph advances the argument; transitions show logic.	Logical order with minor jumps.	Order is loose; paragraphs repeat or drift.	No discernible structure.
Style and conventions	10	Formal academic voice, present tense for literature, correct grammar and MLA format.	Formal, precise, present tense; MLA format; virtually error-free.	Formal with a few errors that do not obscure meaning.	Informal or error-prone in ways that distract.	Errors obscure meaning.

Exemplar paragraph: Rainsford's early view is turned against him. The text makes this visible when it says “The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees” (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 14). He tells Whitney "The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees," and Zaroff makes him a huntee; at the end, "He had never slept in a better bed," suggesting he has become a hunter of men too. A full paper would carry this reading through the beginning, middle and end, and answer the strongest competing reading.

Essay assignments

Essay: Hunter and hunted

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Most Dangerous Game teaches about hunter and hunted. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Richard Connell develops hunter and hunted in The Most Dangerous Game. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Richard Connell develops hunter and hunted across The Most Dangerous Game. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Most Dangerous Game (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of hunter and hunted. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of hunter and hunted in The Most Dangerous Game. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Richard Connell's choices in The Most Dangerous Game (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of hunter and hunted, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Most Dangerous Game's treatment of hunter and hunted in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on hunter and hunted in The Most Dangerous Game that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on hunter and hunted in The Most Dangerous Game. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about hunter and hunted in The Most Dangerous Game, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on hunter and hunted in The Most Dangerous Game, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Civilization and savagery

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Most Dangerous Game teaches about civilization and savagery. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Richard Connell develops civilization and savagery in The Most Dangerous Game. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Richard Connell develops civilization and savagery across The Most Dangerous Game. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Most Dangerous Game (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of civilization and savagery. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of civilization and savagery in The Most Dangerous Game. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Richard Connell's choices in The Most Dangerous Game (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of civilization and savagery, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Most Dangerous Game's treatment of civilization and savagery in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on civilization and savagery in The Most Dangerous Game that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on civilization and savagery in The Most Dangerous Game. Name your critical method, apply it closely,

and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about civilization and savagery in The Most Dangerous Game, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on civilization and savagery in The Most Dangerous Game, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Survival

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Most Dangerous Game teaches about survival. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Richard Connell develops survival in The Most Dangerous Game. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Richard Connell develops survival across The Most Dangerous Game. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Most Dangerous Game (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of survival. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of survival in The Most Dangerous Game. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Richard Connell's choices in The Most Dangerous Game (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of survival, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Most Dangerous Game's treatment of survival in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on survival in The Most Dangerous Game that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on survival in The Most Dangerous Game. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

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Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on survival in The Most Dangerous Game, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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